

The Toronto Raccoon Activity Index*

A Serious Exploration of a Joke Dataset

Lewis Sang

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I'll write it

1 Introduction

The raccoon (*Procyon lotor*) is a mammal native to North America. While predominately located on the East coast and the Great Lakes regions, raccoon populations have spread rapidly across the continent since the introduction of European colonists and the fur trade. Notably, they have found considerable success in metropolitan areas, due to factors such as readily available food sources like waste bins and gardens, accessible habitats in housing and buildings, and a lack of natural predators. However, raccoons also pose risks to their neighbours, as they commonly carry diseases such as rabies and *Baylisascaris procyonis*, both of which cause severe neurological harm in humans. Moreover, raccoons nesting often cause dangerous and costly property damage.

In Toronto, the raccoon is a divisive figure. The “raccoon problem” is one that has plagued Toronto City Council, with a number of mayors investing in methods of population control, “raccoon-proof” garbage bins, and even floating the possibility of extermination programs. Conversely, Conrad - a dead raccoon left on a sidewalk for fourteen hours that became a national media sensation - was memorialised with a heritage plaque on the corner of Yonge and Church on the eve of his tenth anniversary in 2025. The raccoon is seen as a symbol of adaptability, resilience, and part of life in the Greater Toronto Area (GTA) - so much so that City of Toronto’s Open Data team released a Toronto Raccoon Activity Index (TRAI) dataset on April 1, 2026, describing the raccoon as a “prominent feature of Toronto’s urban environment” that necessitated detailed, hourly observations across the 25 wards of the city. While the TRAI is ostensibly a joke and likely randomly generated, its mere existence symbolises the complex relationship between the raccoons and the citizens of Toronto.

*View the code and datasets at <https://github.com/shadowmisstep/yyz-raccoon-activity>

This paper seeks to analyse the TRAI through two lenses - as a legitimate dataset of raccoon behaviour across the city, and as a deliberately created product that may reveal underlying assumptions and biased understandings of Toronto’s neighborhoods.

2 Data

The two datasets utilised in this paper were obtained through the OpenDataToronto Library - the Toronto Raccoon Activity Index, and the 2021 One Variable sheet from the Ward Profiles (25-Ward Model) dataset. Data was extracted using R and the `opendatatatoronto` library, and cleaned using the `tidyverse` package.

2.1 The Toronto Raccoon Activity Index

2.1.1 Description

The TRAI details hourly raccoon appearances across the 25 wards of the GTA from January 1 to March 30 of 2024 (Table 1). Additionally, the TRAI records the number of compromised green compost bins, average raccoon weight in kilograms, and the raccoon’s “confidence.” Given that there is no given methodology or definition for characterising raccoon behaviour, this metric was not used in analysis.

Table 1: Sample Raccoon Activity Across 5 Wards of Toronto January 1, 2024 00:00

Ward	Units Observed	Bins Compromised	Raccoon Confidence	Average Weight (kg)
Davenport	20	13	10.0	6.06
Spadina-Fort York	16	10	10.0	4.85
University- Rosedale	19	14	10.0	6.21
Toronto-St. Paul’s	12	7	7.9	6.05
Toronto Centre	18	11	10.0	6.48
Toronto-Danforth	19	14	10.0	5.19

Alongside raccoon behaviour, the TRAI records human-raccoon interactions (Table 2). These interactions are defined as confrontations (described as “standoffs”) with the number of incidents, average duration of the interaction in seconds, proximity to a patio, and complaints filed are recorded.

Table 2: Raccoon-Human Interactions in Toronto-Danforth January 1, 2024 from 00:00 to 06:00

Hour	Human Raccoon Confrontations	Average Standoff Duration (s)	Patio Proximity	Complaints Logged
0	4	31	FALSE	2
1	1	25	FALSE	2
2	3	16	FALSE	1
3	2	26	FALSE	2
4	0	0	FALSE	0
5	0	0	FALSE	0

2.1.2 Cleaning and Aggregation

This data can be analysed across a number of categories, such as creating an average of raccoon observations per hour, or the daily average raccoon appearances in the quarter. The **aggregate** function of the **stats** package is used to create these averaged datasets (Table 3).

Table 3: Daily and Hourly Averages of Observed Raccoons Across Toronto from January to March 2024

(a) Daily Average		(b) Hourly Average	
Date	Raccoons Observed	Hour	Raccoons Observed
2024-01-01	5.72	0	15.05
2024-01-02	5.68	1	15.11
2024-01-03	5.77	2	15.04
2024-01-04	5.71	3	15.06
2024-01-05	5.72	4	2.60
2024-01-06	7.56	5	2.63

2.2 Ward Profiles

2.2.1 Description

The Ward Profiles dataset is based on the 2021 Census of Population conducted by the Government of Canada. The dataset records the demographics for the population and households of each ward, including ethnocultural origins, language, education status, and employment. See Table 4 for a sample of how the data is structured.

Table 4: Age Demographics of Toronto and Sample Wards Based on 2021 Census Data

Age Range	Toronto	Ward 1	Ward 2
0 to 4 years	123385	5755	5105
5 to 9 years	128805	6160	5825
10 to 14 years	131150	6585	6370
15 to 19 years	133820	7085	6540
20 to 24 years	184570	9645	6600
25 to 29 years	242615	10095	6820
30 to 34 years	245705	8125	6755
35 to 39 years	212845	7265	7395
40 to 44 years	184665	6905	7045
45 to 49 years	174740	7035	7135
50 to 54 years	182850	7515	8380
55 to 59 years	189830	7925	9530
60 to 64 years	169370	7070	8675
65 to 69 years	139105	5495	7165
70 to 74 years	118280	4745	6020
75 to 79 years	79765	3140	4060
80 to 84 years	59920	2390	3575
85 to 89 years	37815	1435	2555
90 years and over	22060	745	1650

2.3 Cleaning and Merging

As the TRAI and the Ward Profiles share the same ID, each ward’s demographics can be compared with corresponding raccoon behaviour by merging these datasets.